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Epilogue

Translating Homer as a Woman

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I am, as far as I know, the first woman to have translated the *Odyssey* complete into English (Norton, 2017).¹ The new century has been a golden age for new translations from Greek and Roman literature into English, and many ancient texts have recently been translated for the first time by women.²

For me, this is not merely an interesting piece of trivia; it is essential to my project. In this chapter I discuss the specific challenges for a feminist in translating the *Odyssey*—a text which inscribes and valorizes androcentric values. I fully acknowledge that these values are present in the poem. Penelope is presented as praiseworthy insofar as she manages to wait faithfully for her husband for twenty years, while Odysseus has his various affairs and flirtations along the way. The stories of the adulterous, murderous Clytemnestra, and the adulterous Helen, whose extramarital affair was the premise for the Trojan War, are repeatedly cited in the poem as counterparts to the fidelity and loyalty of Penelope. The slave

¹ In several other modern languages, there have been women translators of Homer for much longer, including Anne Dacier, *née* Le Fèvre, who translated the poem into French prose in 1712. On Dacier's life and work, see Farnham 1976.

² In 2016 Caroline Alexander was the first woman to publish a translation of the *Iliad*. The past couple of decades have seen vastly more anglophone translations of classical texts by women than ever before—including Sarah Ruden's *Aeneid*, Sappho by Diane Rayor and Anne Carson, Anne Carson's various Greek tragedies, Pamela Mensch's Plutarch, Arrian, and Herodotus, Jo Balmer's various poetry collections based on classical female authors, and many more.

women who slept with the suitors are hanged. Men's desire for women is presented as a problem in this poem, and women are made to suffer for it. Odysseus is able to inhabit multiple different identities as he travels the world; Penelope stays home and has only two choices: to wait for him, or to remarry. The choice is not presented as value neutral. The female characters in the text are defined in terms of their relationships with the male protagonist, as either obstacles or helpers on his mission. The narrative is primarily focalized through Odysseus and the (implicitly male) narrator; we very rarely get access to the thoughts and perspectives of female characters. The reader or listener is invited to root for, and celebrate, the success of Odysseus in evading bewitching females and monstrous foreigners, reaching his homeland, outwitting and slaughtering his male rivals, and regaining control of his property (including his slaves, at least those who survive his homecoming), and his voluntarily subordinate wife.

Lillian Doherty has helpfully defined the *Odyssey* as a relatively 'closed' text, whose dominant narrative insists on androcentric values—as well as valorizing other forms of social inequality, such as slavery.³ She argues that even with a 'closed' text, an ingenious and insistently resistant reader can find a number of gaps or fissures or inconsistencies which can enable a more 'open' reading. I see my translation as building on this work, and trying to create an English Homer that invites a critical response to its own dominant ideology.

Translation studies, including both the history of translation and translation theory, have become increasingly important fields in recent years. Feminist translation theory is a nascent but still, I would argue, underdeveloped area within both gender/feminist studies and translation studies.⁴ Feminist translation theorists have taught us how the most common metaphors by which we think of translation—in terms of fidelity or infidelity, as well as origin or parent, versus the copy or the child—are implicated in androcentric, heteronormative ideas of family structure.⁵ In translation studies, we have been taught—above all by the

³ Doherty 1995.

⁴ See Flotow 1997 on the still-new possibilities of intersection between Anglo-American women's studies and European translation studies.

⁵ Chamberlain 2000 (first published 1988). Cf. Hellerstein 2000, who discusses translation in terms of the creation of Eve out of Adam's rib.

work of Antoine Berman and Lawrence Venuti—that there is something wrong with the dominant anglophone model of translation, which involves fluent erasure of the translation's status as a translation.⁶ Instead, translations are supposed to 'foreignize' and to make themselves 'visible' as translations. These critics tell us that there is an 'ethical' imperative to remain faithful to the alterity of the original text and its culture, and to use translation to challenge the hegemony of the receiving culture of English. Feminist translation theorists have tried to meld this cluster of ideas with the ongoing work of gender theory. A great deal of recent attention has rightly been paid to the topic of how to translate neglected women's writing from under-read languages, especially from non-Western countries and cultures.⁷ In the case of marginalized authors and texts, it is relatively easy to see how it might be an ethical imperative to welcome the foreign text into the English language without making its style seem too familiar, or to engage in an open encounter with the foreign text, hoping to find oneself transformed in the process.⁸ But it is different in the case of a text whose dominant values the translator finds not only foreign but unethical.⁹ I do not believe that I have an ethical obligation to be welcoming or submissive to the elements of Homeric ideology that I find ethically abhorrent. Suzanne Jill Levine and Carol Maier have usefully discussed this difficulty in the case of more recent texts, analyzing the challenges for a female and feminist translator of translating 'oppressively male' authors, whose work uses language to 'mock women and their words'.¹⁰ Levine uses the Ovidian image of Echo, asking if the feminist translator is 'a double betrayer, to play Echo to this Narcissus?' (Levine 1984: 92).¹¹ The question of a translator's 'fidelity' to the original is always implicated in unequal, unethical gender hierarchies.¹² The translator's obligation to be faithful to an original, which always retains the ultimate authority, mirrors the double standard by which women, but not men, are praised

⁶ Berman 2000; Venuti 1995. Compare also Johnson 1985, who makes a persuasive case against the 'desire to be innocent', given the (Derridean) awareness that language exists always in 'the space of foreignness to itself' (Johnson 1985: 146).

⁷ See Castro and Ergun 2017; Spivak 2000.

⁸ Cf. Castro and Ergun 2017.

⁹ Cf. Tissot 2017, who argues for the 'unceasing negotiation of the universal'.

¹⁰ Levine 1984 and Maier 1985, both discussed in Flotow 1997: 25–7.

¹¹ See Flotow 1997: 27 on what might be missing from these discussions.

¹² As Chamberlain 2000 notes.

or blamed on the grounds of their sexually exclusive bond with their partners. I had no desire to think of myself as a loyal Penelope to Homer's Odysseus, nor as a 'treacherous' Clytemnestra or Helen. Similarly, I was uncomfortable about playing the good hostess to Homer as a visiting foreign dignitary, down on his luck—given the unequal status of female hosts in the world of the *Odyssey* itself, and given the ways that the institution of *xenia*, again in the poem itself, is tied up with social institutions of inequality. Chamberlain (2000) and Simon (1996) have described the possibility of a translator working as a 'hijacker' or a 'terrorist' to the source text, a possibility that worries many readers, including feminists (Arrojo 1995).¹³ Levine has described her own work as 'subversive' (Levine 1984). But there are costs for a translator to adopting an overtly aggressive, oppositional, or murderous attitude towards her original—not least, that she may end up unread, or at the very least, mistrusted as a source. She may thereby fail to provide any mind-expanding benefit to the first-time and Greekless readers whom she most hopes to reach.

It would be possible for a feminist translator simply not to translate androcentric texts like the *Odyssey*. One might, instead, choose to translate the works of neglected non-anglophone, non-white women writers—although there are not many of these surviving in ancient Greek.¹⁴ Or one might choose to produce not a translation, but a creative response to Homer—like Alice Oswald's *Memorial*, or Margaret Atwood's *Penelopiad*.

But if no feminists translate classical texts, then students and general readers will have to rely on translations that inscribe uncritical modern assumptions about sex and gender. I felt a responsibility to provide Greekless readers with a reliable, authoritative substitute for the Greek text that would take its complex representations of social inequality, including gender inequality, more seriously than I felt had been done before.

It may seem obvious that Odysseus is the 'hero' of the poem—the character through whose eyes we see most of the action, and whom we are expected to admire—and that the poem's values are androcentric,

¹³ See also Santaemilia 2017: 26, who discusses suspicion among translators about feminist translation practices.

¹⁴ Cf. Spivak 2000.

militaristic, elitist, consumerist, xenophobic, and so on. These things are true, but only up to a point. Odysseus is the primary narrative focus, but he is not the only character with a perspective, and there are moments when the *Odyssey* seems to contradict or undermine its own dominant scheme of values. Even if its narrative is predominantly ‘closed’, there are ‘open’ elements within it. I wanted my translation to acknowledge this feature of the original as fully as possible. Moreover, I wanted to make the ethical problems in the original as visible as possible—for example by calling the slaves in the poem ‘slaves’, rather than ‘servants’ or ‘maids’. I do not see either of these primary frameworks of my work in terms of ‘hijacking’, nor am I imposing my own values on the poem. Like my male predecessors, I provide a careful, responsible interpretation of the Greek original, shaped by my scholarly labors, my values, and my literary sensibility.

I will describe my approach to the challenges of this project by sketching out Seven Types of Feminist Translation Strategy. I discuss the first rule at the most length, since it affects all of the others.

1. *Be (Somewhat) Visible*. Lawrence Venuti has most famously called for translators, and their readers, to question the dominant Anglo-American assumption that literary translations are good insofar as they mask their own status as translations.¹⁵ Venuti argues that fluent, domesticizing translations bolster the hegemony of anglophone literary norms, and can serve conservative ideologies (see Rule #2). Feminist translators have often echoed Venuti’s resistance to the idealizing of the translator’s invisibility.¹⁶ In my translation of the *Odyssey*, I have aimed to make my translation visible in particular ways, in order to invite a critical, engaged response from my readers. Many people are not fully aware of the fact that all translations exist within the social and linguistic fabric of their own time. Archaizing translations of classical texts tend to obscure this fact, and present themselves as if they could offer the anglophone reader undiluted access to the original text. Richmond Lattimore’s long (though not actually hexameter) lines, as well as his odd, foreignized English, have the useful effect of reminding the reader

¹⁵ Venuti 1995.

¹⁶ See the seminal article by Godard 1989, discussed in a more global perspective in Pas and Zaborowska 2017.

that she is not reading a native anglophone poem, as does Rodney Merrill's recent hexameter version.¹⁷ But archaizing has very high costs. It may lull the Greekless reader into thinking that she is reading something that is more 'authentically' engaged with the original text than is in fact the case. Archaizing and foreignizing may also silence critical impulses, and may confirm prejudices that many readers will already have: that ancient texts are boring, and that they express a predictable set of values. The original Homeric text has a haunting, regular rhythm, and a vast literary and stylistic range, none of which can be captured unless the translator has some kind of literary ambition of her own.

I hope that my own critical responses to the text will also be visible to a certain extent. But I have constantly curtailed my desire to comment, since my primary responsibility is to tell it, not to tell about it. I chose to limit myself to the same number of lines as the Greek original, to maintain the rapid narrative pace of the original, and because all translations without this kind of limit end up being longer than the original. All translators fight against and within the desire to comment on their target texts. I hoped my deliberate act of constant self-discipline, sticking to a fixed, regular rhythm and maintaining the same number of lines as the original, would assure readers of my deep commitment to the translatorly pledge. All my words are responses to Homer's words, although like all translators, I weave them into my own, entirely different, piece of cloth. I also hope that the clarity and directness of my language will invite the reader to pursue her own critical responses.

It may be helpful here to turn back for a moment to Levine's image of the feminist translator as a potentially treacherous Echo, bound to a male object of desire to whom she is invisible, and subordinating, betraying, or destroying her own physical being in the service of this love. In Ovid's story (*Metamorphoses* 3.339–510), Juno punishes Echo for helping her fellow nymphs, by taking away her ability to initiate speech—a story which does seem a useful parable for the dangers threatening the feminist translator. But it is also worth emphasizing that she continues to articulate her own desires, even when her only verbal material is provided by Narcissus. In translating Homer, I have tried to be Echo

¹⁷ Lattimore 1965.

with a difference: an Echo who always uses words that are not her own, but does not let herself become invisible or immaterial in the process.

2. *Watch the Time.* Translators of ancient texts are often accused of ‘anachronism’ if their language feels markedly modern. This criticism is usually ill-conceived, since archaizing contemporary English is obviously no closer to Homeric Greek than any other style. I avoided language that felt too conversational, since including too many fashionable phrases is an easy way to make a translation date instantly, and my regular verse rhythm marks the literariness of my language. But I wanted my phrasing to feel fairly close to the language that contemporary people might actually speak. I hoped the reader would occasionally feel a sense of vertiginous shock at hovering between two vastly separate times and cultures: the world of now, and the world of then. I used a native anglophone verse form—the iambic pentameter—to signal my awareness of modern and early modern English drama and epic. Our readings of Homer will necessarily be informed by our readings of much more recent literature. A translation of an ancient text straddles two entirely different moments in time, and I wanted my readers to feel aware of both, and invited to measure the distance between them.

A very clear, direct, sometimes markedly ‘modern’ style seemed to me the best strategy for inviting readers to take the text seriously, not only as a historical document; many of the social inequalities and double standards evoked by the *Odyssey* are present, perhaps in different ways, in our own societies.

3. *Give Voice.* As I have noted, the dominant narrative perspective in the *Odyssey* is largely aligned with its protagonist and his values. But his is not the only voice in the poem. I worked, wherever possible, to make vivid the voices of Odysseus’ opponents and victims, and to treat them with as much narrative respect as I could—while still remaining within the parameters of the original. I tried to allow for deep and genuine sympathy for the other sides to the story, and also to make clear that the alternatives are indeed real alternatives: that this story does not need to be seen only from its protagonist’s point of view.

4. *Keep Your Distance.* This is the mirror image of the previous strategy. Where characters within the text express problematic values, or do horrible things, it is possible for the translation to keep them stylistically at arm’s length, by irony or by making it clear that these values may not be shared by the narrator. I used the Homeric epithets,

for example, to shape the reader's responses to 'scheming' or 'lying' or 'calculated' Odysseus (for *polymetis*: 'of much guile' or 'tricky').

5. *Contain Multitudes*. The original text contains a certain amount of ambiguity and ambivalence about some essential questions—such as whether Odysseus' homecoming and final act of revenge should be seen in terms of 'justice'; or whether Cyclopic culture is lacking in any law or reverence for the gods. As far as possible, I have tried to underline important fault lines of contradiction, to encourage a critical and open reading.

6. *Tell It How It Is*. Calling the slaves 'slaves' comes under this rubric, as does the use of fairly simple, plain language, to invite an engaged response from the reader.

7. *Don't Be Evil*. Everyone, male and female, is inevitably influenced by the norms and prejudices of contemporary society. But it is possible to be more or less conscious of particular types of prejudice, and to try not to inscribe native forms of discrimination in a translation of a foreign text. This is an important point, because feminist translators risk being accused of imposing their own ideology on the original.¹⁸ In fact, a more ideologically conscious translator may impose less, not more. For instance, in the passage where the slave women are hanged—discussed below—most (male) anglophone translators import derogatory language (like 'sluts'), although the original has no term of abuse.

Three Passages: The Dog Face, the Sluts, and the Bed

For the remainder of this chapter, I discuss three key moments in the text that speak directly to questions of gender, and compare my translation with some of the most widely read contemporary English translations, all of which are by men.

My first comes in Book 4, when Telemachus is visiting Menelaus and Helen, who are reunited in Sparta. Telemachus has not revealed his identity, but Helen, far smarter than her brash husband, realizes who he is by an uncanny intuition, having only seen him before as an infant,

¹⁸ The same is true of feminist scholars and critics, as is well discussed by Doherty 1995: 180.

just before the Achaeans sailed away to Troy. Helen says that the Achaeans went to war for her sake, and she uses an epithet to describe herself: *kunopis*, literally, 'dog-face'—Book 4, 145–6. Richmond Lattimore's Helen says the same: 'for the sake of shameless me'. Robert Fagles's Helen says, 'just for my sake, shameless whore that I was'. Stanley Lombardo's Helen says, 'for my sake, shameless thing that I was' (Lombardo 2000). Stephen Mitchell makes her call herself a 'bitch' (Mitchell 2013).

The word *kunopis* suggests, literally, 'dog-faced' or 'dog-eyed'. It is a common trope in archaic and classical Greek culture to use 'dog' (*kuon*) as an undifferentiated insult term, hurled at men but more commonly used against women. The symbolic usage of dog insults is significantly different from all other forms of animal insult.¹⁹ Most imply a specific accusation: to call someone a 'pig' suggests that she or he is greedy or dirty. Moreover, most animal insults imply a particular negative idea about the animal in question. Dogs are different, because they live in human houses, eat human food and work far more intimately with humans than any other animal. They are almost, but not quite, like humans—just as male enemies, or, especially, women, can be imagined (by men) as quasi-humans. The metaphorical usage of *kuon* is thus quite different in its import from the English term of abuse, 'bitch'—which suggests a specific insult (cruelty). By contrast, *kuon* can imply a whole range of different possible insults, from savage aggression (dogs hunt and bite) to a failure to adhere to social boundaries (dogs live with humans, but fail to act like civilized people). Its advantage as an insult term is its vagueness.

The compound word, *κυνῶπις*, has its own distinct usage and connotations. It is not a normal way to impose linguistic shame on human women; indeed, the semi-divine Helen is the only mortal to whom it is applied. Unlike *kuon*—which can be applied to lower-class people or slaves of either gender, to imply that they have no claim any social agency or humanity—*kunopis* is, in extant Greek literature, only applied to the semi-divine Helen and to goddesses, including the Furies.²⁰ The word localizes the danger in the person's face or eyes.

¹⁹ I draw here from an excellent anthropological study of dogs in the archaic Greek imaginary: Franco 2014.

²⁰ Cf. *Iliad* 3.180. Helen's application of the term to herself is generally read as self-abuse, but it need not be read in this way.

A final essential point is that the causal relationship here is importantly ambiguous, as is the narrative point of view. Helen might be saying, 'The war started because of me, because I was dog-faced,' or 'because of me, despite my being dog-face', or 'because of me, a person who happens to have a canine sort of face'. The epithet might or might not be endorsed by the speaker. Helen could be saying, 'because I am, as a matter of fact, dog-faced'; or, 'they were motivated by their own perception of my face as dog-like.'

Most previous translators skip the metaphor, and all of them import self-slug-shaming which is certainly not a necessary interpretation of the original text (Rule 7). I tried to take full account of the philological facts. My Helen speaks of 'the day the Greeks marched off to Troy, their minds / fixated on the war and violence. / They made my face the cause that hounded them.' I wanted the self-assertive Helen of the *Odyssey* not to speak out of character (by suddenly blaming herself, for no good reason), and I pushed back against the absurd, still pervasive falsehood that wars are caused by women's failure to repress their sexual impulses.

My second example is the moment when Odysseus, his son, and his two enslaved henchmen have slaughtered the suitors, and Odysseus instructs Telemachus and the others to take the slave women who slept with the suitors outside, and hack all the life out of them with long swords. Telemachus shows an uncharacteristic amount of initiative, and insists that they must instead be murdered by hanging, because they are too metaphorically dirty for him to touch with his sword (22.461–73).

To what extent should we see this terrible action through the eyes of Telemachus? Four key elements in the passage shape any answer to these questions: the initial epithet describing Telemachus, *pepneumenos* ('thoughtful' or 'aware'); Telemachus' words about what the women did; the simile; and the final vision of the dying women's twitching feet.

In Lattimore's translation, the epithet is rendered as 'thoughtful'—a word that suggests a good kind of attention. In Fagles, Telemachus is 'stern', as if he were enacting just punishment on people who had genuinely done something wrong. In Lombardo, he speaks 'in his cool-headed way', a phrase that dispels any suspicion that Telemachus might conceivably be motivated by his own sense of sexual inadequacy.

Lattimore's Telemachus explains his motives by saying, 'I would not take away the lives of these creatures by any / clean death'. The word

'creatures' has no parallel in the Greek. In Fagles, Telemachus is directly abusive, saying, 'No clean death for the likes of them, by god!', and going on to exclaim, 'You sluts—the suitors' whores!' The Greek says that the women spent their nights beside the suitors, but does not pass linguistic judgment on the behavior (see Rule 6). Lombardo's Telemachus is a little more restrained, but similarly abusive, declaring, 'I won't allow a clean death for these women / —the suitors' sluts.' Both Fagles and Lombardo clearly assume that to state that the women were habitually sleeping with the suitors is equivalent to accusing them of being 'sluts'—despite the fact that the original simply makes a statement about behavior, without any judgment attached.

In my translation, I have tried to create some distance from Telemachus (Rule 4), allowing the reader to see him not as an instrument of 'moral' justice, but as an immature young man indulging in a creepy impulse towards sexualized violence:

Telemachus thought, then took initiative,
insisting,
 'I refuse to grant these girls
a clean death, since they poured down shame on me
and Mother, when they lay beside the suitors.'

I hoped to make him like somebody struggling desperately to assert his authority, rather than a genuine authority. My use of the capital letter ('Mother') was designed to underline his immaturity, by having him make a failed attempt to use adult language. Unlike the other translators, I do not import abusive language, even in the mouth of this unreliable and cruel boy (Rule 7).

In rendering the simile, the most important question is how shocked we should feel about the nasty surprise experienced by the birds, who fly home and find a deadly trap. Lattimore's birds fly 'into a snare set up for them in a thicket, trying / to find a resting place, but the sleep given them was hateful'. The trap is here made to sound more passive than it is in the Greek; it is simply 'given', as if inevitably. In Fagles, the point of comparison becomes unclear, since his birds seem to flap their wings against the trap before they actually reach it, 'beating their spread wings / against some snare rigged up in thickets—flying in / for a cozy nest but a grizzly bed receives them . . .' The confusion about the birds' movements makes their motivations unclear: are they protesting, or just trying to get

'cozy'? The childish half-rhyme ('cozy . . . grizly') also makes it difficult to take these birds seriously. Lombardo habitually sets off the similes in italics, which effectively signals that this will be a moment to pause and enjoy a beautiful description, albeit of a violent event:

*Long-winged thrushes, or doves, making their way
To their roosts, fall into a snare set in the thicket,
And the bed that receives them is far from welcome.*

These birds are strikingly incompetent or passive: they 'fall' into the snare, an action which a healthy bird with its wits about it surely could avoid.

In my own version of the simile, I wanted to make clear that these birds are not fools, that their motives are human as much as avine, and that they die not from natural causes, but through human agency.

As doves or thrushes spread their wings to fly
home to their nests, but someone set a trap—
they crash into a net, a bitter bed-time.

I wanted to underline the fact that the birds' desire is not for something peculiar to the bird world ('roosts' or 'cozy nest'), but the same thing that people want, including Odysseus himself: to go home and go to bed. Odysseus' homecoming deprives many other people of their homes.

I turn finally to the last two details, the killers' motive and the dying movements of the slaughtered women's feet. Lattimore tells us they were tied up, 'so that their death would be most pitiful. / They struggled with their feet for a little, not for very long.' Here we see the women making a futile effort not to die, and insofar as we pity them, the killer's goals have been achieved. Fagles gives us more opportunity to gawk at their pain, and provides more of a celebratory atmosphere for these slaves' last moments: 'so all might die a pitiful, ghastly death . . . / they kicked up heels for a little—not for long.' There is here no glimmer of protest from the narrator; instead, this group hanging is presented as the last party that the 'sluts' will enjoy. In Lombardo, the women remain more like birds than humans: 'It was a most piteous death. Their feet fluttered / For a little while, but not for long.'

In my version, I wanted the reader to feel the women's pain as much as possible—not as a source of vicarious thrills, but as something genuinely painful, suffered by people who are truly people. I called them 'girls' here,

to make clear their vulnerability and youth—with a little nod to the enslaved ‘girls’ of *The Handmaid’s Tale*:

the girls, their heads all in a row,
were strung up with the noose around their necks
to make their death an agony. They gasped,
feet twitching for a while, but not for long.

The original word *oiktista* at the end of this passage can suggest ‘inducing a great deal of pity’, as if from an outside observer. But it can also suggest ‘most painful’, if the experience is imagined from the sufferer’s point of view—and hence my use of the word ‘agony’ (Rule 3). When the victims of hanging are hoisted up from the ground by the noose, death happens by strangulation and takes up to twenty minutes—in contrast to the quicker death of ‘fall jump’ hanging, more often used for executions in modern societies. I hoped that using ‘gasped’ might help readers feel the women’s desperation during this torturous murder—and that ‘twitching’ might underline the fact that, as slaves, their movements were never wholly their own.

I turn finally to the reunion of Odysseus and Penelope—the passage when Odysseus explains how he built their marriage bed out of an olive tree that was already growing on the location of the palace, and expresses his hurt, rage, and fear at the thought that somebody might have moved this bed elsewhere—as Penelope implies. At this, Penelope at last accepts him as her husband, embraces him, explains her long resistance with a reference to Helen’s affair with Paris, and Odysseus weeps as they hold each other. Then comes the famous ‘reverse simile’ (Foley 1978), in which the narrator invokes the experience of the survivors of shipwreck, and the point of comparison turns out to be not Odysseus, but Penelope, clinging to her husband (*Odyssey* 23.202–41). The scene is a defining moment in the depiction of the relationship. Any translator has to decide how close or how distant this couple are, and what the forces are that bring them together, and keep them apart.

In my version, I hoped to bring out the anxieties and vulnerabilities of both parties. While conveying the emotional intensity and intimacy of the scene, I wanted to define the relationship as a careful balancing act between two desperate people in entirely different positions of power. Some feminist readers have tried to avoid seeing Penelope as a victim, emphasizing her capacity for agency and her intelligence; others have

stressed that her options are extremely limited, that she is repeatedly deprived of information, and that the narrative perspective is usually aligned with Odysseus.²¹ I have more sympathy with the second approach, although I do not believe that people who have been put into constricted social roles need to be despised. Penelope's choices are far more limited than those of her husband, and the couple's relationship is built on fear and desperation, of quite different kinds—as well as physical affection, a wary appreciation for the other's intelligence, and a shared economic interest in keeping the house. Moreover, even in this scene that includes the reverse simile, we are granted only limited insight into Penelope's state of mind.

Odysseus declares that 'nothing could be better than when two / live in one house, their minds in harmony / husband and wife' (6.182–4; my version). The positive image of harmonious marriage offered here has encouraged many readers to see Odysseus' own marriage as a partnership of equals. However, the words are expressed not to Penelope but to Nausicaa, whom Odysseus is trying to win over by some judicious flirtation. The minds of Odysseus and Penelope have 'harmony' or 'like-mindedness' (*homophrosyne*) in the sense that they care about each other and that they are both competent within their own separate spheres. But they are certainly not equals in social and economic power. They do not share everything in their minds and histories with each other, and they do not make decisions jointly. I hoped my translation would—like the original, as I read it—show how this uneasy coalition makes human and emotional sense for each of them, but in quite different ways.

Odysseus' anxiety about the bed being moved expresses not only his concern about his property (as the translation by Fagles implies) or fear of castration (as suggested by Lombardo's version), but fear that another man might replace him and become the husband of Penelope. He says, in my version, 'But woman, wife, I do not know if someone / —a man —has cut the olive trunk and moved / my bed, or if it is still safe.' In the Greek, he calls her *gunai* (23.203), a word which means either 'woman' or 'wife'; I used both words in English, to underline the fact that Odysseus'

²¹ There is an excellent overview of scholarship on Penelope in Doherty 1995. 'Positive' readings include Felson-Rubin 1994; Murnaghan 2009 emphasizes Penelope's lack of power and lack of information.

question is precisely about which she is to him. My Penelope responds not by surrendering, but with a release of physical and emotional tension: 'her heart and body suddenly relaxed.' Her final recognition of her long-lost husband can be seen not as willful resistance followed by an equally irrational desire to surrender, but as a comprehensible response to a situation about which she was kept in the dark for so long, and finally confronted by Odysseus' admission of vulnerability, in his admission that it was possible that the bed he worked so hard to create could be moved by another man. Odysseus holds almost all the cards of power in this marriage; Penelope relaxes only once she forces him to remember that her single card—the ability to remarry, allowing another man to move the bed—is one that has the capacity to hurt him deeply, when she plays it at just the right time. In my translation of the line in which Penelope declares her recognition, she emphasizes his persuasiveness, not her own peculiarities: 'You made my stubborn heart believe in you.' The first thing she says, in recognizing Odysseus as her husband, is 'Do not be angry with me'—an acknowledgement that he has a violent temper. I wanted to keep a kind of wariness in Penelope's attitude, which is reinforced a little later, when she cross-questions him about what will happen next, when he leaves her yet again.

Penelope's reference to Helen cuts in several different directions. On the one hand, Penelope is underlining the essential difference between herself, as the faithful wife, and Helen the adulteress—and thereby re-inscribing the androcentric idea that women are valuable only insofar as they remain sexually loyal to their husbands (see Doherty 1995; cf. Blondell 2013). She is responding to her husband's identification of himself as a particular man (Odysseus), by identifying herself as the 'right' kind of woman, and underlining the androcentric idea that there are only two kinds of woman. On the other hand, the particular way that Penelope evokes the story does not quite reinforce the idea that Helen was bad. She emphasizes three separate circumstances which seem to excuse Helen: first, she was deceived by a wicked, clever, deceitful man—of whom there are many, including the one embracing Penelope; second, she was impelled by a god; and third, she had no idea of the consequences of her actions. Penelope has emphasized that she and Odysseus have been cursed by the gods—just as Helen was driven by a god; and the description of Paris as a clever trickster who managed to fool his victim with lies makes him sound very much like Penelope's own husband, the

master of deceit. The third element—that Helen had no idea that her affair would cause the Trojan War—is phrased in a way that is importantly ambiguous. Penelope says that from Helen’s *ate* (‘madness’ or, in my version, ‘passion’—a kind of craziness that need not be pathological) came ‘our sorrow’. This phrase could refer to the deaths of men in war; or more precisely to the suffering of the quasi-widowed Penelope, missing Odysseus; or it could suggest that Penelope’s own present desire, for her own clever trickster, is what caused, and continues to cause, her suffering. In any case, Helen is presented as somebody who suffered from being kept in the dark, just as Penelope was kept in the dark continuously and repeatedly, by Telemachus and Odysseus and Athena. If she had known the full facts of her situation, she might have had a hope of making an informed decision. I wanted my translation to pick up the original ambiguities in the Helen reference, rather than make Penelope speak in more moralizing tones about the adulteress than she does in the Greek (Rule #7), as other translations have done. I hope that my translation hints at the possibility that Penelope might not be entirely on board with an androcentric vision of her own marriage, and that readers need not accept these debatable values (Rules #3 and #5). The Helen reference can remind us of the fact that women in Homeric society may have very limited choices, or no choice at all (Rule #4); and Penelope need not be blaming Helen, nonsensically, for this situation. In my version, Penelope says of Helen, ‘it was a goddess / who made her do it, putting in her heart / the passion that first caused my grief as well.’ This contrasts sharply with Fagles, who has Penelope condemn the ‘shameless work’ of Helen when she ‘sporting’ with Paris; and Lombardo, whose Penelope complains of the ‘dreadful act’ that Helen did, calling the love affair a ‘horror that brought suffering to us as well’.

Penelope’s relationship with her husband is associated, above all, with vulnerability and pain, and as a result there is always a wariness in how she speaks to him. In the simile, I wanted to emphasize not pure joy, but relief at survival, with perhaps a memory, in the minds of both parties, of all those who perished—at Troy, on the journey, and inside the palace. ‘Grateful to be alive, they crawl to land.’ The re-establishment of the marriage is a deep emotional experience, not least because it will enable Odysseus and Penelope to retain the wealth of the palace, and regain control of Ithaca—although in her case, it is vicarious possession and vicarious control. In the embrace, I kept the language simple, mostly

monosyllabic: 'So glad she was to see her own dear husband, / and her white arms would not let go his neck.' I hoped it would be clear from my translation that Penelope has intense feelings, which include a desperate wish to survive and to stay in her own home, as well as as love for the violent, controlling husband who left her alone twenty years before. She makes a momentous choice in accepting him for whom he says he is; as the Helen reference suggests, Penelope herself knows that her choice is born of desperation, out of limited or non-existent other options.

Women-friendly *Odysseys*, Then and Now

In conclusion, I would like to look back twenty years to 1996, when Robert Fagles published his *Odyssey*. Fagles was much praised by male reviewers for his rendering of 'Homer's women'; the translation was not, as far as I am aware, reviewed by women in any prominent publications. Garry Wills in the *New Yorker* was lavish in his praise, in a piece titled 'Homer's Women' and subtitled 'A politically correct Odyssey turns out to be a very good thing'. Wills claimed that Fagles was affected by the impact of 'women's studies' on Homeric scholarship, and that this had led him to appreciate the 'psychological subtlety with which Homer presents women' (Wills 1997: 75). Soon afterwards, in an interview on PBS (Farnsworth 1997), Fagles emphasized that the 'sympathetic' depiction of female characters was a 'main point of emphasis' for him and Bernard Knox (who wrote the introduction to Fagles's translation). Fagles presents himself as a man to whom 'women have meant a great deal'. When asked a low-ball question about his (supposedly very successful) handling of Homeric women, he remarks, 'Well, I was talking to my wife about it this morning'—without revealing what his wife said in reply, if anything. Fagles reads his own version of the olive-tree bed scene, and comments that 'anyone has to recognize, that *The Odyssey* is a deeply married kind of poem'. He points to his translation of the moment when Penelope embraces Odysseus ('never for a moment let him go'), and interprets it as a 'seal' of a permanent relationship: 'Finally in one embrace, that one moment of embrace, their remarriage is sealed.'

The sentimentalizing is a problem, not only because it feels hokey but, more seriously, because it ignores the huge inequality of economic and social power in this idealized relationship. As I have emphasized, Penelope's choices operate within an extremely circumscribed arena. In a fine

article on the marriage bed as an object and symbol in the *Odyssey*, Froma Zeitlin shows that the bed means different things from the perspective of Penelope and Odysseus: for the wife, it is a symbol of fidelity, and for the husband, of identity; the ‘apparent’ symmetry in the scene is not real (Zeitlin 1996). Curiously, both Fagles and Wills cite Zeitlin’s article as justification for their claim that the *Odyssey* is ‘sympathetic’ to women, and (a supposedly related point) pro-marriage—having perhaps misremembered or misunderstood Zeitlin.²² Both Wills and Fagles make the extraordinary assumption that the heteronormative institution of marriage is always a positive force for women. The *Odyssey*’s emphasis on marriage is taken to be a sign of sympathy for women—since marriage is (these men assume) what women are for.

The presentation of Fagles’s *Odyssey*, both by Fagles himself and by Wills, as ‘politically correct’ or even ‘feminist’ could be read as a measure of how far gender awareness has come in the past twenty years. But many people, including translators of classical texts, still make similar assumptions in 2017. As their references to Zeitlin show, Fagles and Wills had feminist scholarship available to them, from which they could have profited. The lesson to draw here is that a translator’s ideological approach makes a real difference, and that the world of classics desperately needs more diligent, thoughtful, literary translators who are willing to be more critical of the power imbalances both of the classical world and of our own societies.

Women translators are not necessarily feminists, and male translators can be quite capable of doing this kind of work; but it is work that needs to be done, not only for the field of classics but for the wider world. Canonical texts such as the *Odyssey* are often read by impressionable young people—and, in fact, older people and scholars—not simply as historical documents, but as lessons in how society really works, and how human life has always been. If we present non-specialists with *Odysseys* that normalize the linguistic and physical abuse of women (for instance by glorifying the hanging of the ‘slut’ slaves), we are failing

²² ‘I think I’ve been assisted greatly by certain wonderful feminist critics I can think, especially a colleague named Froma Zeitland [*sic*], who has written about the bed especially’ (Farnsworth 1997); ‘Froma Zeitlin, a professor of classics at Princeton, has shown how rich and profound a symbol is the bed of Penelope, which is carved out of a tree still rooted in the ground’ (Wills 1997: 75).

to tell the truth about the original text, and we may also be doing real ethical damage. Feminist classicists need to translate as well as communicate, with each other but also with a wider world.²³ The dead white men, including Homer, are no longer the exclusive property of living white men.

²³ McManus 1997 says nothing about translation; there is also no discussion of translation in the fine volume of Rabinowitz and Richlin 1993.

